

AEO & GEO for Dev Tools

A playbook for showing up in ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Google's AI Overviews, and what Google's February 2026 Discover Core Update changed for developer content teams.

65%

of devs use AI tools
weekly or more.

5.4x

more traffic to human
content vs. AI-only

49%

of search results now
include AI Overviews

“Our first pieces were published within weeks and ranked within the first month. What impressed me the most was that as traffic grew, I was expecting a slight drop in conversion rates from visitors to signups, surprisingly it stayed consistent at 10-15%. Helping us not only hit our goals but exceed them.”



Dawn Parzych,
Head of Marketing at Shorebird

The New Developer Discovery Environment

Traditional SEO still matters, but developers are increasingly turning to AI-powered chat interfaces, code generation tools, and AI agents to decide which technologies to use and how to use them.

Two new disciplines have emerged in response:

Answer Engine Optimization

Optimizing content for AI-powered search interfaces like ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Google's AI Overviews. AEO focuses on content structure, freshness, and brand mentions to increase visibility in AI-generated answers in real time.

Generative Engine Optimization

Optimizing content to appear in AI-generated recommendations and summaries produced by large language models. GEO focuses on how LLMs process, understand, and cite content, with emphasis on training data influence over time.

Note: Google's own guidance frames AEO and GEO as extensions of SEO. Their generative AI features are rooted in the same core Search ranking systems, so strong foundational SEO is still the starting point.

Google's February 2026 Discover Core Update

On February 5, 2026, Google released its first-ever Discover-specific core update, treating Discover as a separate ranking ecosystem with its own quality criteria. For developer content teams, three changes matter most.

1	Topic-by-topic expertise evaluation Google now evaluates expertise per subject area. Authority earned in one topic stays there. Each content vertical must independently demonstrate depth.
2	Anti-sensationalism enforcement Headlines must “capture the essence of the content.” Clickbait, exaggerated claims, and emotional manipulation are actively penalized in Google Discover and in LLM citation patterns alike.
3	Original, in-depth content prioritization The update rewards content backed by first-hand testing, proprietary frameworks, and quantified results. Aggregation and curation without added analysis are explicitly disadvantaged.

Key Takeaway: The delta between how search engines view your content and how LLMs view your content is not that big. If you've been producing high-quality technical content, you're not starting from scratch.

Do SEO fundamentals still apply?

Yes, but the signals LLMs and AI-powered search weigh most heavily have shifted. Here are some additional areas to focus on.

Content freshness

AI models favor recently updated content. Deprecated code or outdated API references erode reader trust and hurt LLM citations. Refresh technical content at least once a year.

Structure that AI can extract

Format for easy extraction: summaries at the top, comparison tables, self-contained sections, and strong internal/external links. Each section should make sense independently.

Brand mentions across the web

Brand mentions across crawlable platforms carry more weight than backlinks to specific pages. Smaller brands can close the gap with established players by earning mentions on the right platforms.

Comparisons and roundups

Comparison and roundup content guides LLMs to associate your tool with specific categories and use cases. Include decision frameworks and multi-criteria comparisons.

"I was thoroughly impressed by the smooth onboarding and ability to adapt to our product suite. Draft.dev's attention to detail and dedication to aligning content with our brand have significantly impacted our developer-focused content strategy."



Em Blitstein,
Senior Content Marketing Manager, Sinch Mailgun

How to Format for the model

Quantified claims

Specific numbers, dates, and “tested-by-us” framing.

Topic-by-Topic Expertise

This is the biggest shift in 2026. Both Google’s Discover update and AI-powered search with AEO emphasize sustained depth in specific subjects. A single comparison article can establish authority the way a content cluster will. Developer tool companies are building content hubs covering tutorials, comparisons, use cases, and interviews you want to own. Draft.dev’s [2026 Developer Marketing Survey](#) found that 63% of respondents want to own. Draft.dev’s [2026 Developer Marketing Survey](#) found that 63% of respondents want to own. Draft.dev’s [2026 Developer Marketing Survey](#) found that 63% of respondents want to own.

optimization policy focuses specifically on training from generative AI recommendations and summaries. Both strategies optimize for how LLMs process and cite content, but AEO emphasizes real-time query responses while GEO focuses on training data influence.

How often should developer content be refreshed?

Developer content, especially tutorials and technical documentation, should be refreshed at least once a year to maintain accuracy and trust. Google’s February 2026 update specifically calls out ‘timely content’ as a ranking factor, and LLMs tend to favor recently updated content over older pages.

FAQs and key takeaways

Conclude with explicit Q&A and decision frameworks.

Schema-marked

Organization, FAQ, and BlogPosting schemas.

```
sen flex-col"> (flex)
on/ld+json">
schema.org", "type": "BlogPosting", "@id": "https://draft.dev/learn/aeo-geo-for-dev-tools#article",
ch in 2026", "description": "Learn how developer tools can optimize for AI-powered search with AEO.
Google's February 2026 update, topic-by-topic expertise signals, and brand menti
", "url": "https://candid-cookie.flywheelsites.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/09/aeo_geo_draft_dev
height": 630, "datePublished": "2025-09-10T08:21:44.000Z", "dateModified": "2026-02-
l": "https://draft.dev/learn/aeo-geo-for-dev-tools", "mainEntityOfPage":
id": "https://draft.dev/learn/aeo-geo-for-dev-tools", "isPartOf": {"@type": "Blog", "name": "Draft.de
/draft.dev/learn"}, "author": {"@type": "Person", "name": "Karl Hughes", "worksFor":
dev/#organization", "type": "Organization"}, "url": "https://draft.dev/about", "description": "Techn
oper tools, generative engine optimization, answer engine optimization", "knowsAbout": ["aeo for
jine optimization", "answer engine optimization"], "sameAs": ["https://www.linkedin.com/in/karlhug
dev/#organization", "type": "Organization"], "articleSection": "content-
: 3097, "lineRequired": "PT16W", "inLanguage": "en-US", "isAccessibleForFree": true, "audience":
audienceType": "Technical Professionals", "keywords": "aeo for developer tools, generative engine
ai search optimization, developer tool discovery", "about": [{"@type": "Thing", "name": "aeo for deve
": "generative engine optimization"}]} == $0
```

“Draft.dev has been instrumental in enabling us to generate the deep technical content we require, something we simply could not produce with our current internal bandwidth. Their capacity to deliver high-quality, specialized articles allows us to consistently engage our audience with valuable material, significantly enhancing our content marketing strategy.”

 **Nicholas DeWald,**
Technical Product Writer, Prove

How to Format for the human

Skimmable intro

High-level summary or bullet points in the first 200 words.

strategies:

1. **Topic-by-topic expertise now drives visibility** – Google's February 2026 Discover Core Update evaluates authority per subject area, not at the domain level
2. **Content freshness beats domain age** – AI models favor recently updated content over older authoritative pages
3. **Brand mentions outweigh backlinks** – LLMs weight positive mentions across platforms more than traditional link metrics
4. **Structure drives visibility** – FAQs, comparisons, tables, and clear formatting help AI extract and cite your content
5. **Human expertise remains essential** – AI-only content generates 5.4x less traffic than human-written content

If you've been creating quality technical content, you're already positioned well. The February 2026 update reinforces that strategic adjustments for AI discovery can amplify your existing

Requirement	Previous (2025)	Current (2026)
Published episodes	12	3
Consumed hours (30 days)	10,000	2,000
Engaged listeners (30 days)	2,000	1,000
Hosting	Spotify for Creators only	Spotify for Creators or DistroKid partners

Tables & matrices

Use them anywhere you're comparing options.

Internal and external links

Surface the cluster's other pages and sources.

Spotify allows you to add [podcast cover art](#) by tapping **Settings** → **About** on the web app only. It recommends the [following dos and don'ts](#) for new podcasters:

- A dimensions ratio of 1:1 (like 1400x1400 or 3000x3000 pixels)
- Simple or minimalist colors
- Easy-to-read font

Of course, you may require a few additional tools, including Canva, Photoshop, or other similar platforms. You can learn more about the details in our guide to [building your podcast brand](#).

Spotify has the following requirements for podcast thumbnails:

- Horizontal
- 16:9 aspect ratio
- Suggested resolution of 1920 x 1080

“96% of developer marketing teams have tried AI for content. Only 7% find it ‘very useful.’ Most use it for ideation and first drafts, not final publication.” - [Draft.dev 2026 Developer Marketing Survey](#).

What Matters Less for AEO & GEO

Some signals that dominated traditional SEO playbooks for a decade are becoming less important or actively counterproductive for AI visibility.

Domain age and rating

Authority metrics like DA carry less weight in LLM ranking. LLMs evaluate expertise per topic. A new site with deep niche expertise can outrank an older site with shallow breadth.

Traditional backlinks

Still useful for SEO, but answer engines weight positive brand mentions far above backlink quality and quantity.

High-volume AI content

Mass-generated content without human oversight underperforms. AI helps speed workflows, but SME-led content wins on accuracy, usefulness, and traffic. Use AI for ideation and first drafts, with expert review before publication.

Filler and cliched openings

“That said...”, “easier than you think”, “where the rubber meets the road”: Google's Feb 2026 update specifically penalizes padding. Every sentence should add information or insight.

Four content moves that compound for AEO/GEO.

Comparisons & Roundups

Compare honestly and accurately. Publish the canonical version on your site, then tailor versions for Dev.to, partner blogs, and Reddit so LLMs associate your product with others being suggested.

Tutorials & Use Cases

AI code generation is example-driven. Upto-date, real-world tutorials are gold for LLMs. Refresh aggressively. Outdated syntax or deprecated APIs hurt your credibility.

Industry-Specific Guides

Chat-based AI adapts to the user's industry. Vertical-specific guides ("DevOps tools for healthtech," "Tools for fintech compliance") capture niche queries that generic product pages miss.

Proprietary Data

A priority for 2026. "We tested both tools across three deployment scenarios" carries more weight than aggregated reviews. If your team has unique data, surveys, benchmarks, or frameworks, share it openly.

"Partnering with Draft.dev has accelerated our technical content output while also extending the bandwidth of our developer relations team to focus more on core product activities. It is truly high-quality content written by devs for devs, helping devs in the process."

 **Abhishek Iyer,**
Head of Marketing, Descope



Do this

- **Comparisons** with substantiated, decision-framework conclusions.
- **Tutorials** with tested code and current API versions.
- **Vertical-specific** industry guides.
- **Quantified claims** ("we tested X across Y scenarios").
- **Ungated & indexable** versions of every gated asset.
- **SME-written content** with AI for ideation only.
- **Distribution to partner**, community, and newsletter channels.

Not this

- **"What is X?" pages:** AI summaries are absorbing the click-through.
- **Gated content** with no crawlable version, which is invisible to LLMs.
- **Pure AI-generated content** with no expert review.
- **Thin hub pages** that just link out without adding insight.
- **Templated section openers** across every post.
- **Sensationalizing**, clickbait, or curiosity-gap headlines.
- **Filler transitions** and cliched language.

5.4x

More traffic to **human-written content** compared to pure AI-generated content. AI helps teams move faster. Competitive advantage still comes from people with practical knowledge.

Adapt without starting from scratch.

If you've already invested in content marketing and SEO, you're ahead. AEO/GEO optimizes for how developers use AI today. Your existing content investments carry forward.

Expert-written content

The fundamentals hold. SME-led content that solves problems is the foundation for SEO, AEO, and GEO.

Refresh on a cadence

Tutorials and docs at least once a year. Both Google's Discover update and LLMs reward timeliness.

Optimize structure & metadata

FAQs, comparison tables, self-contained sections, and schema markup across the catalog.

Build topic-by-topic depth

Content clusters around specific verticals and use cases, with depth in each.

Spread brand mentions

Brands that engage on Dev.to, Reddit, newsletters, and partner blogs build the mentions that compound over time.

Audit for filler

Cut empty transitions, sensationalism, generic openers, and any sentence that doesn't add information.

AEO/GEO in Action: Real Client Results

The following results come from Draft.dev clients who implemented structured AEO and GEO content strategies. All data is anonymized. Metrics span 2-5 month windows and cover both traditional SEO signals and AI-visibility measures including LLM response presence and citation consistency.

All data represents anonymized performance highlights from Draft.dev client engagements. LLM presence and citation consistency measured via brand-monitoring tooling across a tracked set of target queries

LLM response presence = the % of tracked queries where the client's brand appears in AI-generated responses.

Citation consistency = a 0–1 score measuring how reliably AI tools cite the client across repeated queries on the same topics.

“Draft.dev really accelerated our developer-focused marketing efforts. They really helped us build a competitive advantage as a developer-friendly platform without pulling away our internal technical teams to write that content.”

 **Ravi Dehar,**
PMM Lead, Gusto

Client A: Cloud Infrastructure

This client combined deep technical tutorial content with a structured brand-mention amplification program across developer community platforms. Content was built around specific use-case clusters to earn topic-by-topic authority

Results (*measured over 1 month*)

+80%

growth in monthly
site users

+44%

increase in LLM
response presence

+3%

keywords ranking in
positions 1–3

How can smaller developer tool companies compete?

The February 2026 update creates a genuine opportunity for smaller brands. Google now evaluates expertise per topic. A newer site with deep niche expertise can outrank an established domain with shallow coverage. Focus on building content clusters in specific verticals, amplify brand mentions on developer-focused platforms, and create content that positions your tool in the right categories.

Client B: Developer Platform

This client started with zero measurable AI visibility. The focus was on building a content cluster from scratch. This included writing comparison articles, tutorials, and use-case guides, and then distributing derivative versions across third-party developer platforms to create brand co-occurrence across crawlable sources.

Results (*measured over 3 months*)

0→71%

LLM response
presence

+37%

keywords in positions
1–3

0.84

citation consistency
score

How often should developer content be refreshed?

At minimum once a year for technical tutorials and documentation. Google's February 2026 update explicitly rewards “timely content,” and LLMs tend to favor recently updated pages. Outdated syntax and deprecated API calls erode reader trust and hurt LLM citations.

Client C: Mobile Dev Tools

This early-stage client needed fast results in a competitive niche. The approach combined high-specificity comparison content targeting decision-stage developers with tutorial content built around real deployment workflows.

Results (*measured over 2 months*)

+156%

keywords in
positions 1–3

+114%

keywords in positions
4–10

+16%

LLM response
presence

What content should we avoid?

Generic “What is X?” content (declining click value as AI summaries dominate), gated content without an ungated version, mass AI-generated content without expert oversight, thin hub pages that are just tables of contents, and anything with sensational headlines or filler language.

Client D: DaaS

This client's strategy targeted compounding growth, building topic-specific depth across three content verticals, each with its own cluster of tutorials, comparisons, and industry guides, while steadily growing brand presence in relevant online communities.

Results (*measured over 3 months*)

+30%

LLM response
presence

+14%

citation consistency

+90%

keywords in
positions 1–3

Does Google's AIO guidance contradict the AEO/GEO advice you often see online?

Partly, yes. Google specifically says you don't need to create llms.txt files, “chunk” content for AI, or pursue inauthentic mentions. Their guidance frames AEO/GEO as extensions of foundational SEO. Both converge on the same principle: create unique, expert-led content that's helpful to real people.

Ready to show up where it counts?

We create the content types that drive AEO/GEO performance: technical tutorials with real code, honest product comparisons, industry-specific use case guides, and original research. Our engineers actually test the products they write about. That's what makes the content accurate enough for developers and compelling enough for LLMs to cite.

[Book Discovery Call](#)

Trust by 100+ tech companies

 docker  JETBRAINS  sinch  Redpanda |  amaDEUS  l6ft  bright data  descope

About the Author



Ever since he started a 50-person campus news blog in college, Karl has been obsessed with writing content. After spending 8 years as an engineering leader at venture-funded tech startups in Chicago, he went on to start Draft.dev, helping companies reach software developers through content marketing.

[Book a discovery call](#)

[Read our case studies](#)